

BARRIER METHODS OF CONTRACEPTION

What Are Barrier Methods?

Barrier methods of contraception physically prevent sperm from reaching an egg. Unlike hormonal methods, they are used at the time of intercourse and do not affect the body's hormones.

Types of Barrier Methods

- External (male) condoms: A sheath worn on the penis during intercourse. With perfect use, about 98% effective. With typical use, about 87% effective. The only method that also protects against STIs, including HIV.
- Internal (female) condoms: A pouch inserted into the vagina before intercourse. With typical use, about 79% effective. Also provides STI protection.
- Diaphragm: A shallow silicone cup inserted into the vagina to cover the cervix. Must be used with spermicide. With typical use, about 88% effective. Requires fitting by a healthcare provider.
- Cervical cap: A smaller silicone cup that fits over the cervix. Effectiveness varies by whether the user has given birth. Requires a prescription and fitting.
- Contraceptive sponge: A soft foam device placed over the cervix and pre-filled with spermicide. Available without a prescription.

Spermicide

Spermicide is a chemical that immobilizes or kills sperm. It can be used alone, but is more effective when used with a barrier method. Spermicide does not protect against STIs.

Advantages of Barrier Methods

- No systemic hormonal effects — suitable for those who cannot use hormonal contraception.

- Used only when needed — no ongoing daily regimen.
- External condoms provide dual protection against both pregnancy and STIs.
- Available without a prescription (external and internal condoms, sponge).
- Fertility is unaffected immediately after use.

Limitations to Consider

- Requires correct and consistent use with every act of intercourse.
- Some methods require advance planning or insertion before intercourse.
- Latex allergies may require switching to non-latex alternatives.
- Lower effectiveness compared to LARC or hormonal methods when used alone.

Key Takeaway

Barrier methods offer hormone-free contraception that is effective when used correctly. External condoms remain the best available tool for simultaneous pregnancy and STI prevention.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. (n.d.). Barrier methods of birth control. Trussell, J. (2011).

Contraceptive failure in the United States. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (2020). Contraception.